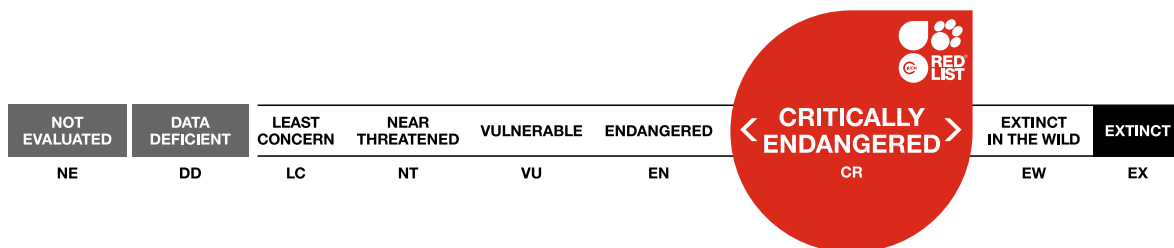


Medusagyne oppositifolia, Jellyfish Tree

Assessment by: Svensson, M.S. & Senterre, B.



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Taxonomy

Kingdom	Phylum	Class	Order	Family
Plantae	Tracheophyta	Magnoliopsida	Malpighiales	Ochnaceae

Scientific Name: *Medusagyne oppositifolia* Baker

Common Name(s):

- English: Jellyfish Tree
- Creoles and pidgins, French-based (Other): Bwa Mediz

Taxonomic Source(s):

POWO. 2024. Plants of the World Online. Facilitated by the Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew. Available at: <http://powo.science.kew.org/>.

Taxonomic Notes:

This species represents the only living representative of the family Medusagynaceae, which is endemic to the Seychelles.

Assessment Information

Red List Category & Criteria: Critically Endangered C2a(ii) [ver 3.1](#)

Year Published: 2025

Date Assessed: August 12, 2025

Justification:

Medusagyne oppositifolia is a small tree endemic to the Seychelles, where it is known from the island of Mahé. The extent of occurrence (EOO) and the area of occupancy (AOO) are estimated at 24 km². Only 86 mature individuals are known *in situ*, despite extensive surveys (in 2011–2013), and the number of mature individuals is inferred to be declining. Approximately 90% of the total population are found in the largest subpopulation, at Bernica, which is also the only subpopulation known to be reproducing. The three other sites consist only of scattered individuals, which do not regenerate. Four out of the six known subpopulations are located within a protected area, representing about 90% of the mature individual trees *in situ*. There are *in situ* and *ex situ* conservation efforts ongoing for the species. It is listed as Critically Endangered.

Previously Published Red List Assessments

[2011 – Critically Endangered \(CR\)](#)

1998 – Critically Endangered (CR)

1997 – Endangered (E)

1978 – Endangered (E)

Geographic Range

Range Description:

This species is endemic to the Seychelles where it is only found on the island of Mahé (Bernica, Mont Sébert, Mont Copolia and Mont Jasmin). Despite extensive exploration having been carried out since the last Red List assessment in 2007 (Matatiken *et al.* 2011), and especially in 2011–2013, no new individual of this species has been discovered.

Country Occurrence:

Native, Extant (resident): Seychelles (Seychelles (main island group))

Population

Medusagyne oppositifolia was thought to be extinct but was rediscovered in 1970 (Wise 1998). There are 86 mature individuals known of this species, occurring in six subpopulations found in the Morne Seychellois National Park (Bernica, Mont Jasmin and Copolia) and Mont Sébert (Matatiken 2006). Extensive surveys have been carried out since 1970, but no further individuals have been encountered. Of the known mature individuals, 90% are found in the largest subpopulation at Bernica, whilst the other three subpopulations consists of scattered individuals. The larger subpopulation is the only one known to reproduce, and it is possible that this subpopulation is big enough to be viable (Finger *et al.* 2011). Dead trees can be observed at these sites, and a past population decline is therefore inferred. The population is predicted to continue to decline due to the lack of regeneration in the three smaller subpopulations and ongoing threats. The species has a fragmented and naturally patchy distribution (Finger *et al.* 2011).

Current Population Trend: Decreasing

Habitat and Ecology (see Appendix for additional information)

This is a small tree up to 10 m in height (Marriott and Sarasan 2010). It grows in edaphic dwarf forests between 150 and 500 m.

Systems: Terrestrial

Use and Trade (see Appendix for additional information)

There is no information on use or trade for this species.

Threats (see Appendix for additional information)

The main threats to this species are invasive species and wildfires, as edaphic subsaxicolous forests of the submontane belt are prone to fire during dry spells (Senterre and Wagner 2014). Poor recruitment/regeneration, its restricted geographic range, limited dispersal and high seedling mortality are all additional stresses facing the species.

Conservation Actions (see Appendix for additional information)

In the 2000s, the Eden Project provided valuable information on the propagation techniques for *Medusagyne oppositifolia*, and the species is kept in at least five *ex situ* collections (BGCI 2025). These are mainly found in Europe, and only a single *ex situ* plant was established in the Seychelles, at the Barbaron Biodiversity Center. In 2022–2024, a new project led by Plant Conservation Action group (PCA), funded by the Franklinia Foundation, intended again to propagate this species in Seychelles and to reintroduce it *in situ*. Seeds were collected in May 2023, and a rich diversity of propagation trials was engaged alongside a detailed monitoring system. This allowed to identify and describe a propagation method that provides over 90% success rate. Over 300 viable seedlings were produced. After a year, the tallest individual seedlings reached about 40 cm high, with multiple branching. Thirteen individuals were planted *in situ* at the Tea Tavern (Morne Seychellois National Park), which serves as a new subpopulation, set in an accessible area of suitable habitat that has been restored over the duration of several projects. More activities are planned for increasing the size of the new *in situ* subpopulation (new plantings) and for the ongoing propagation of this flagship species.

So far, although there has been a significant break-through in terms of the *ex situ* conservation of *M. oppositifolia*, all the *ex situ* material produced is based on seeds collected from four distinct individuals coming from the largest *in situ* subpopulation, at Bernica. In the near future, there are plans to collect seeds from the other three subpopulations.

Four out of the six known subpopulations are located within a protected area, representing about 90% of the wild mature individual trees.

Credits

Assessor(s): Svensson, M.S. & Senterre, B.

Reviewer(s): Hills, R.

Contributor(s): Matatiken, D., Huber, M.J. & Ismail, S.

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External Resources

For [Supplementary Material](#), and for [Images and External Links to Additional Information](#), please see the Red List website.

Appendix

Habitats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Habitat	Season	Suitability	Major Importance?
1. Forest -> 1.5. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Dry	Resident	Suitable	-

Plant and Fungal growth forms

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Plant and Fungal growth forms
TS. Tree - small

Threats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Threat	Timing	Scope	Severity
7. Natural system modifications -> 7.1. Fire & fire suppression -> 7.1.3. Trend Unknown/Unrecorded	Ongoing	-	-
8. Invasive and other problematic species, genes & diseases -> 8.1. Invasive non-native/alien species/diseases -> 8.1.1. Unspecified species	Ongoing	-	-
Stresses: 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation			

Conservation Actions in Place

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Conservation Action in Place
In-place land/water protection
Percentage of population protected by PAs: 81-90
Occurs in at least one protected area: Yes
In-place species management
Successfully reintroduced or introduced benignly: Yes
Subject to ex-situ conservation: Yes
In-place education
Subject to recent education and awareness programmes: No
Included in international legislation: No

Conservation Actions Needed

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Conservation Action Needed	Notes
1. Land/water protection -> 1.1. Site/area protection	-
2. Land/water management -> 2.1. Site/area management	-
3. Species management -> 3.3. Species re-introduction -> 3.3.1. Reintroduction	-
3. Species management -> 3.4. Ex-situ conservation -> 3.4.1. Captive breeding/artificial propagation	-
5. Law & policy -> 5.1. Legislation -> 5.1.2. National level	-
5. Law & policy -> 5.4. Compliance and enforcement -> 5.4.2. National level	-

Research Needed

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Research Needed	Notes
1. Research -> 1.5. Threats	-
2. Conservation Planning -> 2.1. Species Action/Recovery Plan	-
2. Conservation Planning -> 2.2. Area-based Management Plan	-
3. Monitoring -> 3.1. Population trends	-

Additional Data Fields

Distribution
Estimated area of occupancy (AOO) (km ²): 24
Estimated extent of occurrence (EOO) (km ²): 24
Lower elevation limit (m): 150
Upper elevation limit (m): 500
Population
Number of mature individuals: 86
Continuing decline of mature individuals: Yes
Population severely fragmented: Unknown
No. of individuals in largest subpopulation: 77-78
Habitats and Ecology
Continuing decline in area, extent and/or quality of habitat: Yes

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